

How to learn French (what the research says)

The study habits that actually move you from beginner to B1 — and the popular ones that don't.

YOU'LL BE ABLE TO

- ✓ Explain why testing yourself beats rereading
- ✓ Plan spaced reviews instead of cramming
- ✓ Balance your week across input, output, study and fluency
- ✓ Set a realistic timeline to B1 / NCLC 5

When	What to do
Day 1	Work through the module and pass the check
Day 2–3	Do your Daily review: the module's words and anything you missed come back
Day 21	Re-read the Watch out notes and retake the check
End of a level	Take the level checkpoint, which mixes every lesson

Starting point	At 1 hour a day	At 2 hours a day
True beginner	12–15 months	6–8 months
Around A2	5–7 months	3–4 months
Around B1, need exam technique	6–10 weeks	4–6 weeks

KEY PHRASES

Pardon, pouvez-vous répéter, s'il vous plaît ?
Sorry, could you repeat that, please?

Pouvez-vous parler plus lentement ?
Could you speak more slowly?

Je ne comprends pas.
I don't understand.

Qu'est-ce que ça veut dire ?
What does that mean?

Comment dit-on « deadline » en français ?
How do you say "deadline" in French?

Comment ça s'écrit ?
How is that spelled?

J'apprends le français pour immigrer au Canada.
I'm learning French to immigrate to Canada.

Je suis en train d'améliorer mon français.
I'm working on improving my French.

AVOID THESE MISTAKES

X Rereading notes until they feel familiar ✓ **Covering them and recalling**
Familiarity is not memory. Recall is what makes it stick (testing effect).

X Learning 50 isolated words a day ✓ **Learning 10–15 words inside sentences**
Words learned in context are easier to recall and use correctly — gender and prepositions come with them.

X Finishing one grammar topic before starting the next, forever ✓ **Mixing old topics into every session**
Interleaving improves retention and the ability to choose the right form.

X Waiting until you're "ready" to speak ✓ **Speaking from the first week, even badly**
Output reveals gaps that reading hides. The exam tests speaking, so train it.

X Watching native TV with French subtitles from day one ✓ **Graded input you understand ~95% of**
Too many unknown words and you stop acquiring and start guessing.

X Using only a gamified app ✓ **Using apps as one strand of four**
Apps are good for vocabulary review, weak for extended output and real listening.

TIP

When you feel stuck, ask which strand you've skipped this week. For most learners, it's output and fluency — they understand far more than they can say.

How to learn French (what the research says): the rules at a glance

Lesson 0.1

CHEAT CODE Four kinds of practice, equal time

25%

25%

25%

25%

Input · 25%

listen and read for the message

Output · 25%

speak and write to say something real

Language study · 25%

grammar, words, sounds

Fluency · 25%

easy material, at speed

Lesson 0.4

CHEAT CODE Mix topics once you know them

AAA · BBB · CCC

Blocked: fewer errors while practising

vs

ABC · CAB · BCA

Mixed: better results a week later

Lesson 0.6

CHEAT CODE How long to B1

LEVEL	1 H A DAY	2 H A DAY
True beginner	12–15 months	6–8 months
Around A2	5–7 months	3–4 months
Around B1	6–10 weeks	4–6 weeks

Little and often beats long, rare sessions.

Lesson 0.2

CHEAT CODE Rereading feels good. Testing works.

X

Reread

Feels easy · fades within a week

vs

✓

Test yourself

Feels harder · still there a week later

Lesson 0.3

CHEAT CODE Space your reviews



Day 1

Do the module and pass the check



Day 2–3

Do your Daily review



Day 7

Missed answers come back in review



Day 21

Retake the check

Lesson 0.5

CHEAT CODE Understand first, then push yourself

1

Understand

material where you know ~95% of the words

2

Produce

speak and write, mistakes and all

3

Compare and fix

check against the model, try again